

Mastercard Q3 2025

Human Arm Reading Sheet, Outlook and guidance only

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The rules, agreed before any of this was scored

- **What counts as a HOLD.** If the share price moves less than 2% overnight, that counts as no real move. Further out the band widens, because over several days a stock drifts anyway, and we set it so roughly the same share of events still count as HOLD.
- **Write a score, not a decision.** You give a number. The sheet turns it into BUY, HOLD or SELL for you: anything between -0.20 and $+0.20$ is a HOLD, above that a BUY, below it a SELL. Do not work it out yourself, or the rule stops being fixed in advance.
- **Do not look at the price until your score is sealed.** If you see one by accident, say so in the peeked box. Owning up costs us one event. Hiding it costs us the whole result.
- **Time yourself.** How long a read takes is half of what we are measuring, since the point is to compare it against what the model costs.
- **If you used AI at any point, write it down.**
- **When this one came out.** Mastercard reports before the market opens, so we measure from the previous day's closing price to that morning's opening price.
- **Once you seal the first read, leave it alone.** Do not go back and tidy it up after the second read. That is the one thing there is no fixing later.

What you are reading

Reference	MA-20251030
Company	Mastercard Incorporated
Ticker	MA
Quarter	Q3 2025
Reported on	30 October 2025
Which part you get	guidance
Where to find it	Mastercard Q3 2025 earnings call transcript
How to read it	Cold. No charts, no news, no previews, no price screen.

Your hunch, written once per company before you start

One line, written before you open anything: what do you think actually moves this stock? Writing it down first turns a hunch into something you can be proved wrong about, rather than an explanation you reach for afterwards.

Volume growth is never the surprise here; the surprise is always the services mix and FX.

FIRST READ, Outlook and guidance only

What to read. Read only what management says about what is coming: next quarter's guidance, full-year targets, spending plans. Skip the results for the quarter just gone, and skip the Q&A.

Timer

Start timing before you open anything. Stop when the score is written down.

minutes taken	21
saw a price first?	no
used AI?	no

Your score

Score: +0.10

Call: HOLD *(worked out by the formula)*

Why. Guided to the high end of low double digits, but with 4 to 4.5 points of FX tailwind doing much of the work. In line rather than ahead.

FIRST READ SEALED, do not come back to it
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SECOND READ, the whole document

What to read. Now open the whole thing and read all of it, including the parts held back from the first read. Start the timer again.

minutes taken	30
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Your score, second time

Score: +0.25

Call: BUY *(worked out by the formula)*

Why. Flipped to BUY. The reported quarter is stronger than the guide suggests, with 17% growth and cross-border still at 15%.

SECOND READ SEALED

What the market did, only once everything above is sealed

These come from the shared price data rather than from you. Do check the overnight number against a chart once for this company though. A company reporting before the open is measured from the previous day's close; one reporting after the close is measured from that day's close. Getting it the wrong way round flips the answer.

	Raw	Excess	Band	P1 holds	P2 holds
anchor date				29 October 2025	
baseline close (\$)					\$554.58
reaction open (\$)					\$551.56
Overnight	−0.54%	−0.04%	2.00%	yes	no
D+3	−1.90%	−1.31%	3.94%	yes	no
D+5	−0.23%	+1.20%	5.20%	yes	no
D+10	+1.20%	+1.78%	5.20%	yes	no

The band widens further out because a stock drifts over several days whatever the earnings said. Each one is set so roughly the same share of events still count as HOLD. These are fitted on twenty events, so treat them as rough and redo them once everyone's readings are pooled.

How the calls did

- Did it move more than 2% overnight? It moved -0.54%, so no, that is inside the band
- So the right call was: **HOLD**
- First read: **RIGHT** Second read: **WRONG**
- Did the second read change the call? Yes, HOLD to BUY, and changing it HURT.

The second read is not independent of the first, since a call had already been committed to and people rarely talk themselves out of one. Read any flip as a floor on how much the extra material actually mattered, not a measure of it.